

SPIRITUAL TRANSFORMATION OF KURUKASHETRA,

THE LAND OF GEETA

Today, the very name Kurukashetra conjures up images of the epic war fought between the Kaurvas and the Pandvas – a war that has defined us culturally. Many of the momentous events leading up to the war also took place at various sites in Haryana. The roots of the dispute lies at Gurugram , Haryana where both the groups studied together in Guru Dronacharya's gurukul. The kurukshetra war was an event in which kingdoms from the entire country participated. Today, the world recognizes this as the place where Lord Krishna gave the Gita's eternal message to Arjuna, exhorting him to fight the decisive battle against what was not righteous, else he would fail in his duty as a brave warrior, incurring disgrace for generations to come.

Lord Krishna is one of the most beloved figures in our culture and many of us have grown up listening to his exploits as a child and youth in Mathura and Vrindavan. Today both these place are major pilgrimage sites and a major center of religious Tourism in India witnessing millions of footfalls every year. However, it is at Kurushetra that Lord Krishna emerges as a Stateman and Philosopher. Kurushetra is his real Karmabhumi! Somehow, Kurushetra never attained the iconic status that Mathura and Vrindavan achieved- Till now.

What piqued our interest in this destination is the recently concluded India Today Tourism Awards where Kurushetra emerged as the best emerging religious tourism destination. The present Govt. headed by the dynamic and visionary Chief Minister, Sh. Manohar Lal, has been quietly working on several projects that would bring this part of our history alive. We had to see what was happening there!

With a spring in our steps, team India Today left to keep its tryst with the birthplace of the Gita. We left for the dream city on a brisk Friday evening with the menacing clouds on a hot summer day offering reprieve. Taking the ancient Grant Trunk road, we stopped at the famous Dhabas at Murthal famous for their parathas- they lived upto to their name! were at Kurukashetra within hours and the first site we visited was the Brahmsarovar or the sacred pond.



A very large waterbody with the famous Sarvesheshwar Mahadev temple in the center, this was the heart of the town. The sarovar water was very clean and the entire area around the pond was well maintained. A picturesque Aarti is held here every evening where the chanting of Vedic hymns accentuate the spiritual experience of visitors. Definitely worth a visit! Visited by thousands every day, it is the site of the massive Mela held on the Solar eclipse day when lakhs come to take a holy dip in the Sarovar- a kind of a mini-Kumbh.

We leisurely drove down through a laid-out and well-maintained road illumining images depicting scenes from the 'Mahabharata' . This town was steeped in the Gita and Mahabharata lore. What really amazed us was that through this entire stretch, not a stray piece of tetra pack or poly bag was found littered on the road as we see at other places of worship as well as other historical sites. The area around Kurushetra belongs to what is called the 48 Kos- the land between the Saraswati and the Dhrishavati rivers with more than 164 Tirthas. A visit to all these places would take days but it is enough to say that after Kashi, Kurushetra may be the next holiest of places and a must visit for all persons interested in our history and Culture.